

BYU - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG 12

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-25 caliber with a stable QB/RB spine and a defense capable of carrying another contender-level season, but less proven at receiver and in the kicking game than the 12-2 team.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 14 (839 points) · SP+ No. 21
Returning production	64% (No. 17) overall · Off. 58% (No. 53) · Def. 69% (No. 6)
Primer power rating	+15.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	8.8 wins · likely 9-3
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar - Similar underlying quality, with expected record regression from 12-2 because the pass-catcher and specialist turnover is materially larger than the QB/RB continuity suggests.
Confidence	Medium-high

2026 identity: OC Aaron Roderick builds around QB Bear Bachmeier and RB LJ Martin while the pass-catcher hierarchy resets. New DC Kelly Poppinga inherits a veteran core led by DT Keanu Tanuvasa, LB Isaiah Glasker, CB Evan Johnson and S Faletau Satuala, plus LB Cade Uluave.

Bottom line: BYU has a top-25 foundation at QB, RB and defense, but WR/OL turnover and a full specialist reset make another 12-win season a demanding standard.

Beats expectations if: The new receiver rotation supplies enough separation and explosiveness, the OL settles around Mitchell/Gentry without a major protection drop, and Poppinga preserves the defense's top-20 efficiency while the new specialists avoid giving away hidden yards.

Disappoints if: The open WR/OL jobs turn a proven quarterback into a lower-ceiling passer, defensive turnover reduces disruption and coverage stability, and the wholesale specialist reset costs close games.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB stability:** QB Bear Bachmeier is an established returning QB after starting all 14 games in 2025, and RB LJ Martin returns as the lead back.
- 2 ? Key uncertainty:** BYU must replace its top two 2025 starting receivers; the WR order remains open among WRs Jojo Phillips, Reggie Frischknecht, Tiger Bachmeier and Tei Nacua plus transfer WR Kyler Kasper.
- 3 Secondary:** The defense returns 69% of production (No. 6) and still features DT Keanu Tanuvasa, LB Isaiah Glasker, CB Evan Johnson and S Faletau Satuala, with LB Cade Uluave added at linebacker.
- 4 Coaching:** Kelly Poppinga is an internal promotion/changed-role defensive coordinator for 2026, not a same-role returning DC.
- 5 ? Special-teams questions:** Kicker, punter, long snapper and return duties all turn over; P Sam Vander Haar is a material roster absence whose exact departure mechanism remains unresolved.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	12-2 (8-2 Big 12)	● Excellent
Scoring	31.4 PPG	● Very good
Total offense	399.5 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	178.1 YPG · 4.7 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass efficiency	7.67 YPA · 15 TD / 7 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	41.4%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	19.1 PPG allowed	● Very good
Total defense	332.4 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	122.7 YPG · 3.7 YPC	● Very good
Pass defense	209.7 YPG · 6.50 YPA · 17 TD allowed	● Very good

BYU paired strong scoring on both sides with a more ordinary yardage/pass-efficiency offense.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+5.53 · No. 19	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.185 · No. 11	● Elite
Off. success rate	45.7% · No. 37	● Good / above average
Off. explosive-play rate	13.0% · No. 48	● Good / above average
Havoc allowed	13.7% · No. 47	● Good / above average
Opp.-adjusted defense	+7.14 · No. 14	● Elite
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.144 · No. 14	● Elite
Def. success rate allowed	38.2% · No. 32	● Very good
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	10.1% · No. 31	● Very good
Havoc created	15.8% · No. 67	● Average / mixed

Advanced-stat read: The 12-2 record had real support: offensive EPA/play was No. 11, adjusted offense No. 19 and both key defensive ratings No. 14. Explosiveness and defensive havoc were good-to-middling rather than dominant.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Kalani Sitake - returning	● ↔ Program continuity stabilizes major WR/special-teams turnover
OC/QB	Aaron Roderick - returning	● ↔ QB continuity is valuable; exact 2026 headset assignment remains unannounced
DC/ILB	◆ Kelly Poppinga - internal promotion	● ↔ Familiar personnel, new coordinator responsibility

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ WR Kyler Kasper	Oregon	● ↔ Experienced candidate for a major role in the rebuilt WR room.
♦ TE Walker Lyons	USC	● ↑ Major TE role candidate with Mackey recognition and 2025 receiving production.
♦ OT Paki Finau	Washington	● ↔ Material left-tackle candidate, but the job remains open.

Out	To	Loss
WR Chase Roberts	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Major target-share and continuity loss.
TE Carsen Ryan	NFL (Cleveland), Round 7, No. 248	● ↓ Starting TE departs from a rebuilt rotation.
OL Weylin Lapuaho	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ Thirty-eight career starts leave the line.
OL Isaiah Jatta	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Another starting OL departure compounds the rebuild.

Offense net: Lower pass-game and line continuity than 2025, partially offset by a proven QB/RB core and multiple transfer options. ● ↓

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ LB Cade Uluave	California	● ↑ High-end immediate role with Big 12 first-team, Bednarik and Butkus recognition.
♦ CB Jayven Williams	Mississippi State	● ↔ Adds depth and competition to a secondary that lost veteran contributors.

Out	To	Loss
LB Jack Kelly	NFL (N.Y. Giants), Round 6, No. 193	● ↓ Veteran starter leaves despite LB Cade Uluave’s arrival.
S Tanner Wall	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Removes starting safety experience.
CB Mory Bamba	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Another veteran corner/special-teams contributor departs.
DL Logan Lutui	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ Fourteen-game starter leaves the rotation.

Defense net: Still a strong unit because the returning star spine is unusually good, but depth/experience turnover keeps the 2025 top-15 efficiency from being automatic. ● ↔

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	QB/RB continuity with a rebuilt receiver/TE hierarchy.	QB Bear Bachmeier, RB LJ Martin and efficient 2025 play-level offense.	Receiver separation and protection if WR/LT/interior jobs stay unsettled.
Defense	Veteran-centered unit under new DC Kelly Poppinga.	Top-15 adjusted/EPA defense plus strong returning production.	Replacing veteran front/secondary pieces and improving No. 67 havoc creation.
Special teams	Full specialist reset.	SP+ projects roughly average performance.	Kicker, punter, long snapper and return duties remain unsettled.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B+	● ↔	High	Started all 14 games in 2025, giving BYU rare quarterback continuity while the receiver room turns over.
RB	● A	● ↔	High	The safest elite offensive piece and the foundation of BYU's returning backfield.
WR	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	Top targets depart; transfers compete around an otherwise stable QB/RB core.
TE	● B	● ↔	Medium	The most prominent new receiving piece outside the WR competition and a potential pressure-release target for Bachmeier.
OL	● B	● ↓	Medium	OL Bruce Mitchell anchors a line with major departures and open alignment questions.
DL/Edge	● B	● ↔	Medium	Interior defensive anchor for a front replacing DL Logan Lutui and other veteran snaps.
LB	● A–	● ↔	High	Headline defensive addition and a direct replacement-quality hedge for linebacker turnover.
Secondary	● B+	● ↓	Medium-high	Returning corner anchor in a secondary replacing multiple veterans.
Special teams	● C+	● ↓	Low	No locked kicker, punter, long snapper or return plan after multiple material departures.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	HC Kalani Sitake/OC Aaron Roderick continuity offsets a new defensive coordinator.
Overall	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	Top-25 caliber with a stable QB/RB spine and contender-level defense, but less proven at receiver and kicker than last season.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
★ LJ Martin	RB	● National star / conference centerpiece	AP 2nd · Big 12 Preseason Offensive Player of the Year · Big 12 first team · Maxwell · Walter Camp	The safest elite offensive piece and the foundation of BYU's returning backfield.
Bear Bachmeier	QB	● High-end Power 4 returning starter	Maxwell	Started all 14 games in 2025, giving BYU rare quarterback continuity while the receiver room turns over.
◆ Cade Uluave (TR: California)	LB	● High-end conference starter	Big 12 first team · Bednarik · Butkus	Headline defensive addition and a direct replacement-quality hedge for linebacker turnover.
Evan Johnson	CB	● High-end conference starter	Big 12 first team	Returning corner anchor in a secondary replacing multiple veterans.
Faletau Satuala	S	● High-end conference starter	Big 12 first team · Bednarik · Jim Thorpe	Back-end anchor who helps absorb safety and special-teams turnover.
Keanu Tanuvasa	DT	● High-end conference starter	Big 12 first team · Outland	Interior defensive anchor for a front replacing Logan Lutui and other veteran snaps.
Bruce Mitchell	OL	● High-end conference offensive-line anchor	Big 12 first team · Outland · Rimington	Established returner who stabilizes a line with multiple departures and open alignment questions.
◆ Walker Lyons (TR: USC)	TE	● High-upside major-role tight end	John Mackey	The most prominent new receiving piece outside the WR competition and a potential pressure-release target for Bachmeier.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Manageable for a top-25 goal, with Notre Dame the clear ceiling test and road TCU/Utah the most important conference leverage points.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · Moderate · SP+ SOS No. 54
Hardest stretch	at TCU → Iowa State → Notre Dame → at UCF
Swing games	at TCU, at Utah
Advantage	Three nonconference games precede the first bye, and Notre Dame comes to Provo rather than sending BYU on the road.
Expected	8.8 wins · likely 9-3
Floor / ceiling	7-5 / 11-1

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	A 12-2 finish plus an AP No. 14 ranking can create more public respect than the No. 21 SP+ anchor, making price discipline important.
Back them when	The price treats BYU like a generic mid-tier Big 12 team even though Bachmeier/Martin and the defensive spine give the Cougars unusual continuity at high-leverage spots.
Fade/pass when	Asked to lay a premium before the WR/OL order and specialist competitions prove stable, especially in games likely to turn on field position or late kicks.
Key monitor	WR hierarchy, LT/interior OL alignment, DC Kelly Poppinga's transition, all four specialist jobs, P Sam Vander Haar's unresolved roster status
Week 1 baseline	vs. Utah Tech: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: BYU -47.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

BYU starts from a sturdy top-25 base: QB Bear Bachmeier and RB LJ Martin return behind an offense with proven efficiency, while the defense keeps several high-end anchors and adds LB Cade Uluave. The main offensive risk is replacing receiving and line continuity.

A full specialist reset and new DC Kelly Poppinga add volatility, but the schedule is manageable enough for another strong season. **8.8 wins and 9-3** is the baseline, with Notre Dame and the road trips to TCU and Utah defining the ceiling.

About this primer

DRWhittier · cfb.drwhittier.com · X: [@GatorBait7](https://twitter.com/GatorBait7) · Version 1.0 - August 25, 2026

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [camp / roles](#) · [departures](#) · [team source](#) · [team source 2](#) · [team source 3](#) · [team source 4](#)

Last updated: August 25, 2026